

Post-Pandemic Trends in Student Attendance

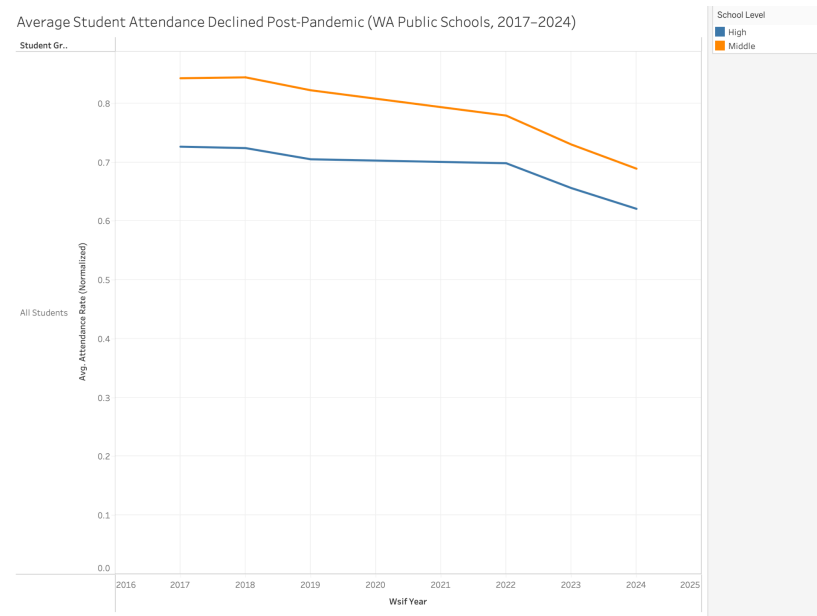
Washington Public Schools, 2017–2024; Paul Mulvaney, February 1st, 2026

Research Question

How did student attendance change following the COVID-19 pandemic, and do recovery patterns differ between middle and high schools?

Data Source

Washington School Improvement Framework (WSIF), Office of Superintendent of Public Instruction (OSPI), school years 2017–2024. Analysis focuses on All Students at the school level, aggregated statewide.



Methods

Raw WSIF CSV files were ingested and analyzed using DuckDB (SQL) and visualized in Tableau Desktop.

Key preparation steps included:

- Stacking multi-year WSIF datasets into a unified analytical table.
- Normalizing attendance rate values to resolve inconsistent units (decimal vs. percentage formats across years).
- Filtering to All Students to avoid subgroup weighting effects.
- Aggregating attendance using Tableau's dynamic averages rather than precomputed values.
- Attendance was examined longitudinally by school level (Middle vs. High). Year 2021 is absent from the dataset and excluded from analysis.

Key Findings

- Attendance declined sharply following the pandemic for both middle and high schools.
- Middle schools consistently maintained higher attendance rates than high schools across all years.
- High schools experienced both a steeper decline and a weaker recovery, with attendance continuing to trend downward through 2024.
- While middle school attendance also declined post-pandemic, partial recovery is evident, and the gap between school levels widened over time.

Interpretation

The divergence between middle and high school attendance suggests that post-pandemic disengagement may be more persistent among older students. This pattern aligns with broader concerns about secondary-level attendance, student motivation, and re-engagement following prolonged disruptions to in-person schooling.

Limitations

- WSIF suppression rules limit visibility into small populations and certain subgroup analyses.
- The absence of 2021 data constrains direct year-over-year pandemic comparisons.
- Statewide averages mask district- and school-level variation.

Implications

Attendance recovery efforts may need to be differentiated by school level, with targeted strategies for high schools. Continued monitoring using consistent metrics will be critical for evaluating the effectiveness of post-pandemic interventions.

Tools & Skills Demonstrated

- SQL (DuckDB): data ingestion, cleaning, aggregation
- Tableau Desktop: calculated fields, filtering, trend visualization
- Public education data literacy
- Clear communication of findings for policy and program audiences

Contact

Paul Mulvaney, MTMS

mrmulvaney5@gmail.com